CHAPTER 5

FAST LANE

It would be wonderful to reflect on the two years between December 2002 when I left high school, and December 2004 when I made my Test debut for South Africa, as an exciting time of swift progress, the purposeful and planned transformation of a school boy into an international cricketer.

It would be wonderful ... but it would be untrue.

In reality, this was a frenetic, stressful and at times frightening period of my life when I was very largely living from day to day, from practice to practice, from match to match, from party to party; it was a period when things ultimately went well for me but it was also a period when things might have gone spectacularly wrong.

Batting? As far as I was concerned, batting amounted to not much more than trying to hit almost every ball for four. Planning? Planning rarely extended beyond phoning around and organising the bar where my friends would meet that evening.

Far from being impeccably organised and marching towards my destiny, I often felt as though I was being carried along by a wave, at the mercy of fate, able to do little more than work hard in the nets, do as I was told by the coaches and hope for the best.

Deep down, I did always believe there was a destiny, always retained an unspoken confidence that, whatever happened, somehow, one way or